FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

RECOGNISING BURNOUT

01

When the love of the game starts to fade

THE QUICK VERSION

> Burnout rarely arrives overnight. It creeps in through tired legs, flat moods and the odd "I don't feel like going tonight." The good news? If you spot it early, you can usually turn it around long before your child walks away from the game for good.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Burnout happens when the demands of sport (training, games, travel, pressure) keep outweighing the rest and enjoyment your child gets back. Their body and mind simply run low on fuel. It isn't laziness and it isn't weakness. It's a signal that something needs to change, and you're often the first person in a position to notice it.

THE THREE WARNING LIGHTS

BODY

- Tired all the time, even after a good sleep
- Niggles and small injuries that keep coming back
- Getting sick more often than usual
- Performance dropping, despite trying hard

INTEREST

- Dragging their feet before training
- "Forgetting" boots, bags or session times
- No longer watching or talking about football
- Asking to skip sessions or games

EMOTIONS

- Snappy, teary or flat around game day
- More worried or anxious than usual
- Really harsh on themselves after mistakes
- Changes in sleep or appetite

One sign is a bad week. Several signs, for several weeks, is a pattern.

Everyone has off days. What you're watching for is a cluster of signs that hangs around. That's your cue to slow down and check in.

TRY THIS

1 Check in, don't interrogate
Side-by-side moments work best: the car, walking the dog, shooting hoops. Try "How's footy feeling lately, out of 10?"

2 Look at the whole week
Add up school, training, games, other sports and homework. Is there a single day with nothing on?

3 Build in a real break
A week or two off, with zero guilt, can recharge a tired player completely. A break is not quitting.

4 Bring back the fun
A kick in the park with no drills, no feedback and no scoreboard. Just play.

5 Talk to the coach together
Coaches can often lighten the load, shift a position or adjust training once they know.

6 Know when to get help
If low mood, sleep or appetite changes last more than a couple of weeks, have a chat with your GP.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"You seem a bit tired of it lately. Want to talk?"	~~"You're just being lazy."~~
"Taking a break doesn't mean quitting."	~~"We've paid for the season, so you're going."~~
"What would make football fun again?"	~~"Other kids manage, why can't you?"~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child has at least one full rest day every week
- [ ] I know how they'd rate their enjoyment right now
- [ ] Football isn't the only thing we talk about at home
- [ ] I've looked out for changes in mood, sleep or energy

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

The players who last are the ones who protect their love for the game. Rest isn't a reward for working hard. It's part of the work.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM